the RP system. However, the state challenged the verdict in the Supreme Court. In 2022, the system's limitations were starkly highlighted again when 19-year-old Ankita Bhandari went missing from a resort in Rishikesh, where she worked. Her disappearance was reported to the local patwari, but no FIR was registered. The case was transferred to the regular police days later, by which time crucial evidence had vanished.

Her employer, Pulkit Arya—the son of a former BJP leader—was later arrested for her murder (and recently sentenced to life imprisonment). The patwari in charge, Vaibhav Pratap, was suspended and arrested for negligence. The case triggered a political storm, with Uttarakhand assembly speaker Ritu Khanduri writing to Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami urging abolition of the colonial-era system. Soon after, the cabinet approved a proposal to phase out the RP. But, in many areas, nothing has changed.

In Jhaid village in Pauri Garhwal district, for instance, residents recall an incident just weeks ago when an elderly man slipped into a gorge. With no road, and no regular police, it took locals and the patwari nearly eight hours to retrieve the body. "It has been nearly 78 years since Independence, and still we have no proper police," says Yogesh Maithani, a local. "Many incidents go unreported...we know the lone patwari has no resources."

CAUGHT BETWEEN ROLES

For patwaris, the job is a daily balancing act between civil and policing duties. "We do the same work as a sub-inspector or inspector, but also handle land records, government schemes—and do it without vehicles, weapons or staff," says Atul Balodhi, president of the Pauri District Patwari Sangh. "Even our safety is at risk."

In disaster-prone hill regions, the patwari is also the first responder during landslides, floods and road accidents. So far, Roshni has dealt with two criminal cases—a missing girl and a village brawl. But as the area's de facto cop, more calls are sure to come. "The worst is accidental deaths. We're expected to shift the body, arrange the postmortem, coordinate with the family—all without any support," she says. "We end up begging locals for help." She now leans on two fellow women patwaris from her training batch—Monika, who covers seven villages, and Sheetal Negi, who manages 14. "That's why we share the *chowki*," she says. "So we can help each other."

Despite multiple court orders and official commitments, progress on dismantling the RP system remains halting—partly due to political and administrative resistance. A senior IPS officer tells INDIA TODAY that the inertia stems from multiple quarters: "Politicians are wary of disturbing a status quo that gives them informal leverage. The civil bureaucracy, especially at the district level, has the most to lose in terms of authority." Even some locals are nostalgic about the patwari as a familiar authority figure.

Uttarakhand IG (law & order) and police spokesperson Nilesh Anand Bharne is emphatic that reforms are under way. "We are committed to improving policing and public services across the state, and replacing revenue police wherever needed. We have already brought large areas and population under regular police," he says.

But with vast swathes of Uttarakhand still being policed by revenue officials, Balodhi complains that they are left to operate with outdated tools and little institutional support. "The world has moved on. But we haven't," he says. "We don't have digital records, we're not connected to a centralised crime tracking network, everything is still on paper." Unless the transition to regular policing is accelerated and implemented in both letter and spirit, accountability, justice and public safety in the hills will remain patchy—and patwaris like Roshni will be left to shoulder impossible burdens. ■



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ATUL BALODHI
President, Pauri District Patwari Sangh



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NILESH ANAND BHARNE
IG (law & order), Uttarakhand

CHANGING THE GUARD

- Since 2023, six new regular police stations and 20 police outposts have come up, taking charge of 1,357 revenue villages
- The jurisdiction of 52 existing police stations and 19 outposts has been expanded to include another 1,800 revenue villages
- The total number of police stations has now reached 166; outposts: 258